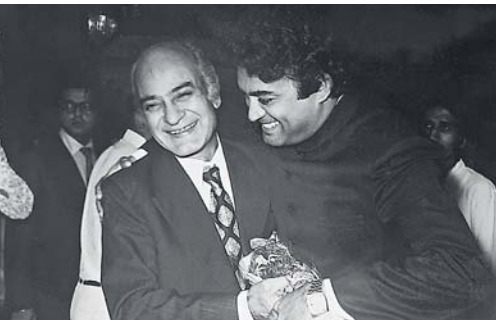




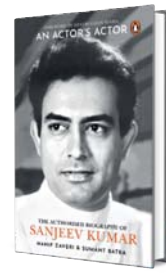




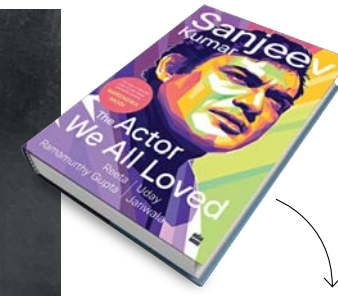
STORIES OF HARI'S UNPUNCTUALITY WERE LEGION, YET THE AUTHORS ARE FORGIVING INSTEAD OF BEING SERIOUSLY CRITICAL OF IT

A LIFE SHORT AND SWEET

Clockwise from top left With director K. Asif on the sets of *Love and God*; a shot from his theatre days, he was not even 30 when he started playing old characters on stage; with friend, philosopher and guide A.K. Hangal; the artist as a young man; and another one from his theatre days



AN ACTOR'S ACTOR: THE AUTHORISED BIOGRAPHY OF SANJEEV KUMAR
BY HANIF ZAVERI AND SUMANT BATRA
PENGUIN RANDOM HOUSE INDIA
₹599; 248 pages



SANJEEV KUMAR: THE ACTOR WE ALL LOVED
BY REETA RAMAMURTHY GUPTA AND UDAY JARIWALA
HARPERCOLLINS INDIA
₹599; 384 pages

There are anecdotes about his generosity of spirit, and an emphasis that though he suffered heartbreak he was not an unhappy man. Inevitably, there is some repetition and overlap between the books—for instance, in the accounts of controversial episodes that once provided fodder to gossip magazines: the near-wedding to Hema Malini (one reason for the relationship to fall through was the condition that his wife would not continue to work), or the closeness with the married Nutan, which culminated in her slapping him in front of a film unit.

Needless to say, given the official status of these books, there is a tendency to tiptoe around less savoury matters. One running theme—which couldn't have been avoided by anyone attempting a Sanjeev Kumar study—is the actor's notorious unpunctuality. The stories of Hari's late-coming are legion, and perhaps this is something the authors could have been more seriously critical of, rather than going down the anodyne route of "but everyone always forgave him because he was so good once he got down to work—or because he was so pleasant". It might also have been a way of commenting on the workings of an often-very-unprofessional film industry where one of its most respected practitioners was regularly allowed to get away with keeping his colleagues waiting for hours. But adulation follows its own rules; what we are left with are tribute books that will hopefully motivate at least a few young readers to seek out and develop an appreciation for the Hindi cinema of Sanjeev Kumar's time. ■

- Jai Arjun Singh

BULLETS OVER BOMBAY: SATYA AND THE HINDI FILM GANGSTER
BY UDAY BHATIA
HARPERCOLLINS INDIA
₹399; 260 pages

The best of many recent books about specific films, this is a study of Ram Gopal Varma's iconic 1998 *Satya*—as a gangster movie, a Bombay movie and a story about outsiders and friendships.

JUBILEE KUMAR: THE LIFE AND TIMES OF A SUPERSTAR
BY SEEMA SONIK ALIMCHAND
HACHETTE INDIA
₹599; 312 pages



Another authorised biography of a star who was once enormously popular but is a distant figure to modern audiences—Rajendra Kumar, one of Hindi cinema's biggest box-office draws in the 1960s.